Introduction to Management MGNT110

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Managing Conflict & Communication

Lecture 5

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Learning Objectives

- Understand conflict as a normal organisational phenomenon
- Identify types and levels of conflict
- Apply strategies to manage conflict
- Understand communication as central to organisations
- Explain the role of polyphony in reducing conflict

What is Conflict?

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What is Conflict?

- Conflict happens when people have:
  - different goals
  - different values
  - different expectations

Note: Not always obvious
Sometimes *perceived*, not real

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Why Conflict Happens

Conflict comes from:

Power differences

- Boss vs employee

Identity differences

- Culture, gender, background

Resource competition

- Time, money, marks

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Levels of Conflict

Interpersonal

- Between individuals
- Most common

Intergroup

- Between teams

Inter-organisational

- Between companies

Apple sues Samsung for $2bn as tech rivals head back to court

Apple says Korean company must pay $40 per device for 'systematically' copying features to use on its newest devices

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Types of Conflict

Task conflict	Relationship conflict	Process conflict	Status
• About the work itself	• Personal/emotional	• How work is done	• Who

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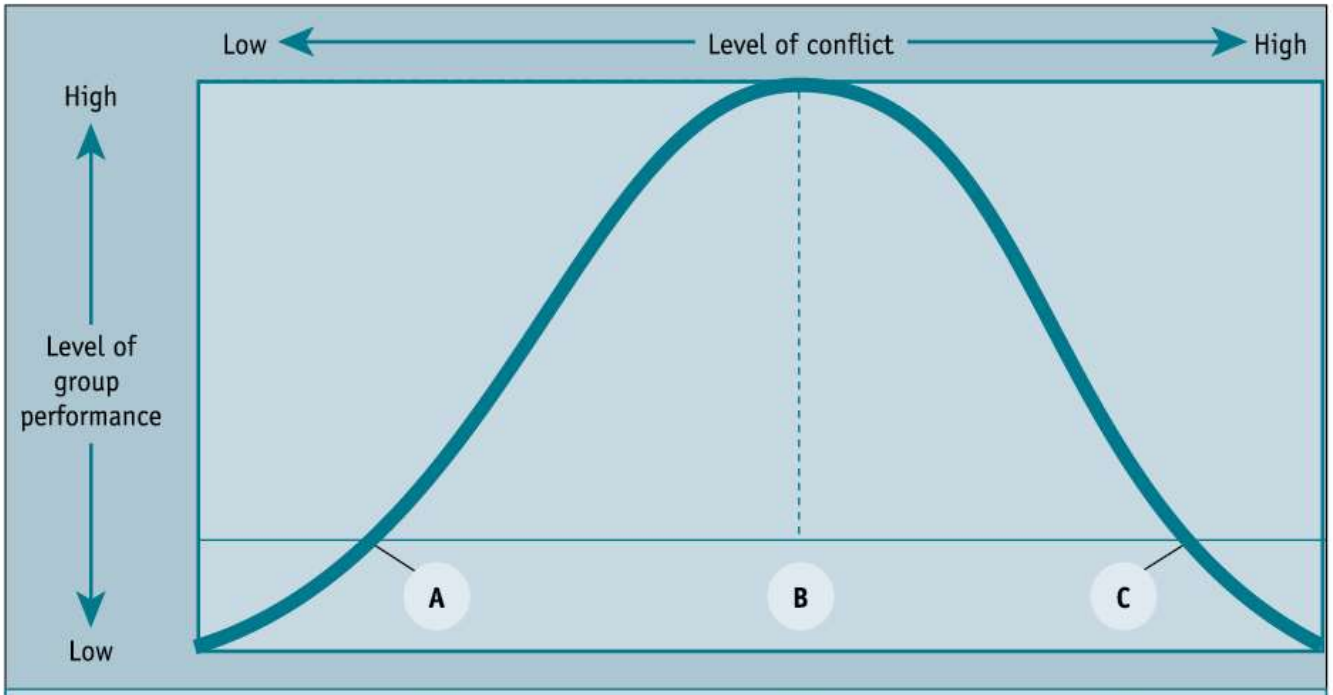
What type of conflict is this?

Functional vs Dysfunctional Conflict

- Functional conflict
  - Sweeps stagnation away and enables creativity
  - Can improve a work group's [performance
  - Force a team to examine a problem and work towards a potential solution.
- Dysfunctional conflict
  - Explodes out of control and destroys creativity
  - Divert energies, disrupt group cohesion and contributes to a negative working environment.

Manager within an organisation should manage - and, on occasion, stimulate conflict to encourage critical thinking, problem solving, creativity and innovation.



Situation	A	B	C
Level of conflict	Low or none	Optimal	High
Type of conflict	Dysfunctional	Functional	Dysfunctional
Group's internal characteristics	Apathetic Stagnant Unresponsive to change Lack of new ideas	Viable Self-critical Innovative	Disruptive Chaotic Uncooperative
Level of group performance	Low	High	Low

FIGURE 5.6

Conflict and group performance

Source: S. Robbins, R. Bergman, I. Stagg & M. Coulter, *Management*, 7th edn, Pearson Australia, 2015, p. 458. Reproduced by permission.

Functional and dysfunctional conflict

- Functional conflict ('constructive' conflict):
  - supports group goals
  - improves group performance
  - results in positive outcomes for individuals, groups and organisations
- Dysfunctional conflict ('destructive conflict'):
  - hinders group performance
  - results in negative outcomes for individuals, groups and organisations

Perspectives on Conflict

Traditional view

Conflict = bad

Avoid it

Human relations view

Conflict = natural

Interactionist view

Conflict = necessary

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Modern organisations prefer:

<u>Interactionist view</u>

We actually NEED some conflict to improve ideas

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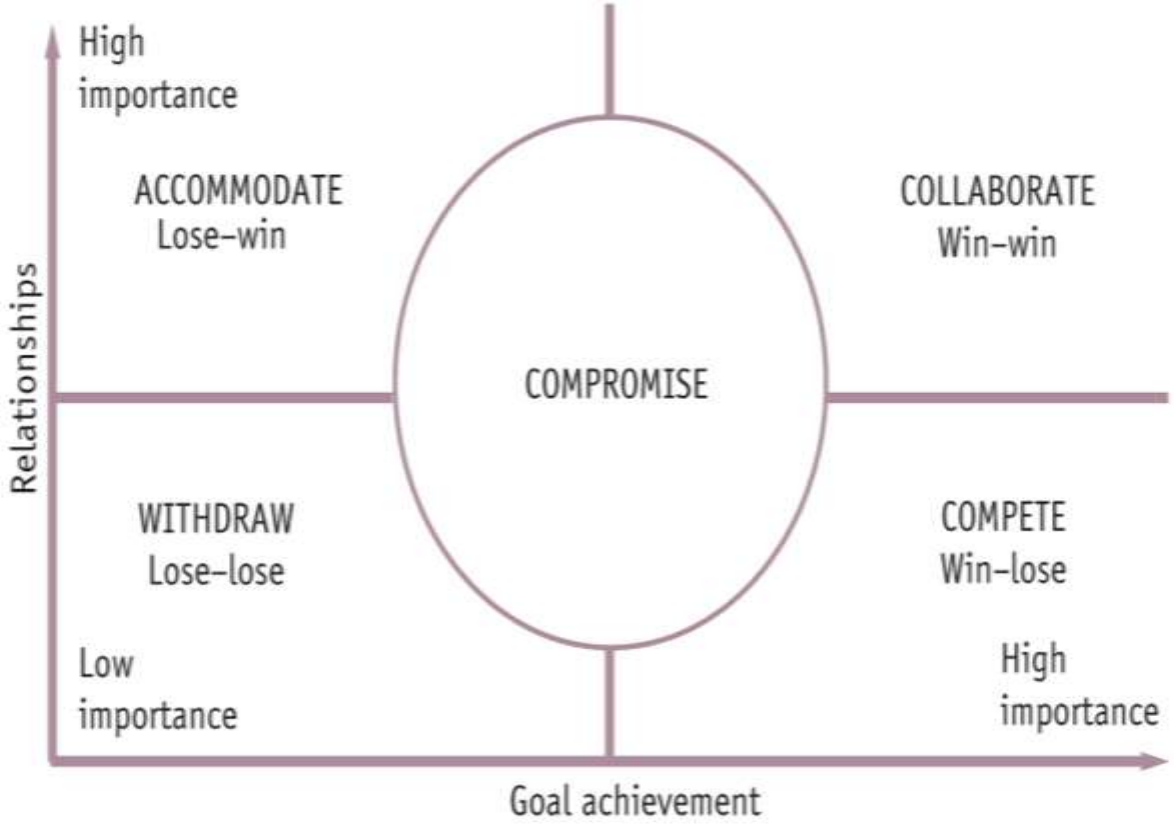

High
importance
ACCOMMODATE
Lose–win
COLLABORATE
Win–win
Relationships
COMPROMISE
WITHDRAW
Lose–lose
COMPETE
Win–lose
Low
importance
High
importance
Goal achievement

Sally vs Sam

Sally would like to watch a movie with Sam, but Sam would rather take a nap at home.

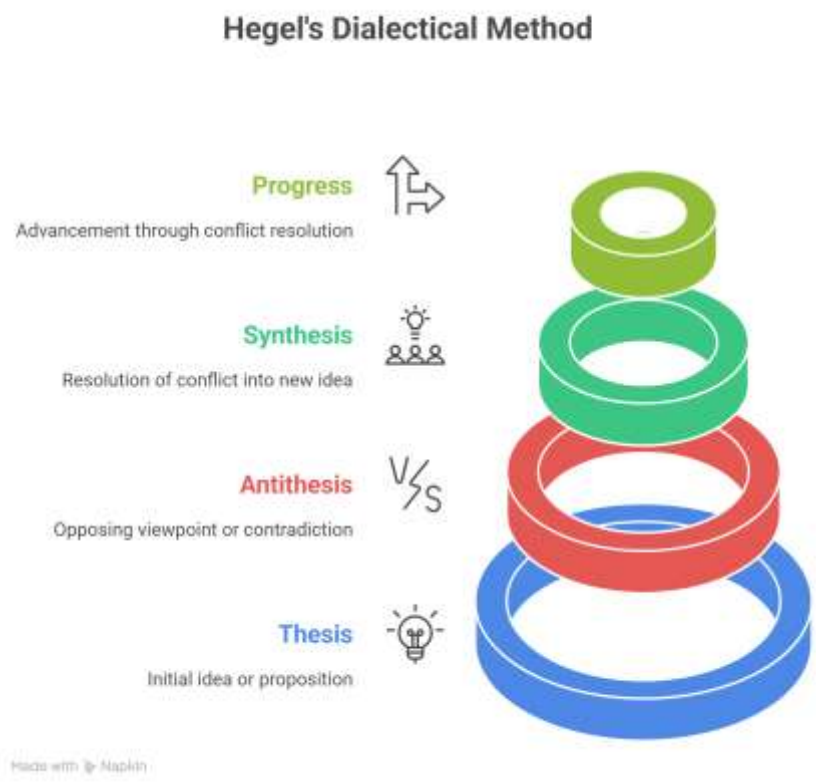
Style	Example	Outcome	A vs B	Context	
1. Avoiding	Not wanting to continue with the situation or conversation.	Lose-Lose	I lose, you lose	Resulted in Sally not watching movie with Sam and Sam not able to nap well after the quarrel.	Sam accused Sally got not being understanding as he just booked out from his camp.
2. Accommodating	Give in to situation and lose something.	Lose-Win	I lose, you win	Resulting in Sally not watching the movie and Sam taking a nap.	Sally gave in to find her own activities and let Sam nap
3. Collaborating	Both achieved ultimate objective of what they wanted.	Win-win	I win, you win	Resulting in both Sally watching movie with Sam, and Sam able to nap.	Sam agreed to bring Sally out for movie and dinner at night. He purchased movie tickets at night and took a nap.
4. Competing	Only A got what she/he wanted.	Win-lose	I win, you lose	Resulting in Sally watching movie with Sam, and Sam not taking a nap.	Sam gave in to Sally. Sally got to watch movie with Sam and Sam did not nap.
5. Compromising	Either A/B gave in to gain some.	? Could result either of the above	I win some you win some I lose some you lose some	Resulting in Sally not watching movie and Sam taking a nap. Or Resulting in Sally watching movie with Sam and Sam not taking a nap.	Sam told Sally that he is really tired and would like to take a nap, he promised that he would watch movie with Sally next time. Sally said ok.

PART 2: THEORY

Dialectical Perspective (Hegel)

- Dialectical perspective, conflict is not something negative.
- Instead, it is a natural process that helps ideas improve over time.
- Conflict = two opposing ideas

dialectic process; a clash of contradictions that resolves into new, higher forms of understanding and freedom.



Like a debate: two sides disagree, but instead of one winning, we get a better combined answer.

Dialogical Perspective (Bakhtin)

- "No single correct answer"
- Multiple voices exist
- No final resolution

Organisations = many voices, not one truth

Meaning is never fixed or isolated; rather, it is created between individuals in ongoing, open-ended exchanges.

(Cohen 2009).

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Music Metaphor

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Music Metaphor

- Organisations are like an orchestra
  - Many people working together
  - Different roles
- Conflict is not noise, it can create harmony
- Instruments = Individuals
  - Each person is different
  - Different skills, personalities, ideas
- Music = Organisational outcome
  - The final performance
  - The result of collaboration

- Think of an orchestra
- Different instruments
- Different sounds
- Must work together

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PART 3: COMMUNICATION

Organisations as Communication Systems

- Most conflicts are NOT about the task
  - They are about communication breakdown
- Importance of Communication
  - Communication:
  - connects tasks
  - coordinates people
  - engages stakeholders

- **Communication Failures → Conflict**
- Conflict often comes from:
  - misunderstanding
  - assumptions
  - unclear messages
  - Many conflicts are NOT real - just miscommunication

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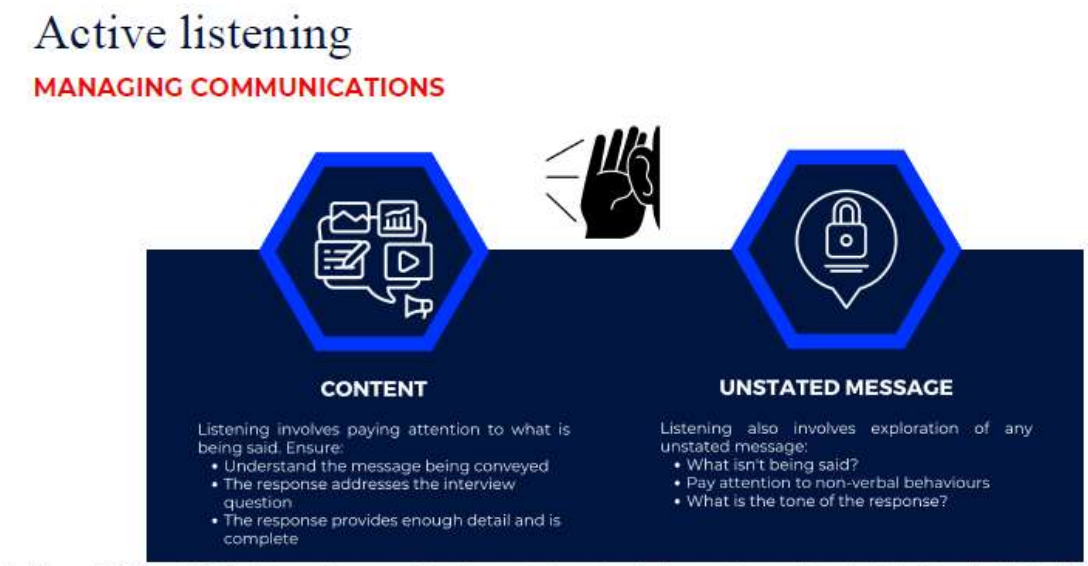
Active Listening

- Good communication = not just talking, includes:
  - listening
  - empathy
  - understanding



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Polyphony

- Polyphony means organisations are made up of multiple voices, all contributing to how meaning is created.
  - In organisations, this means:
  - There are multiple perspectives
  - Different people see things differently
  - No single voice represents the whole truth

Importance of Polyphony

- Strong leadership that encourages a multiplicity of views (polyphony) will uncover different "senses" or narratives
- These stories or narratives can create or reinforce a view or perspective within the organisation with positive or negative consequences
- Encouraging polyphony and multiplicity in sense-making can reduce groupthink and reduce or mitigate conflict

Summary

- Conflict is inevitable
- Not always bad
- Communication is key
- Multiple perspectives matter

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